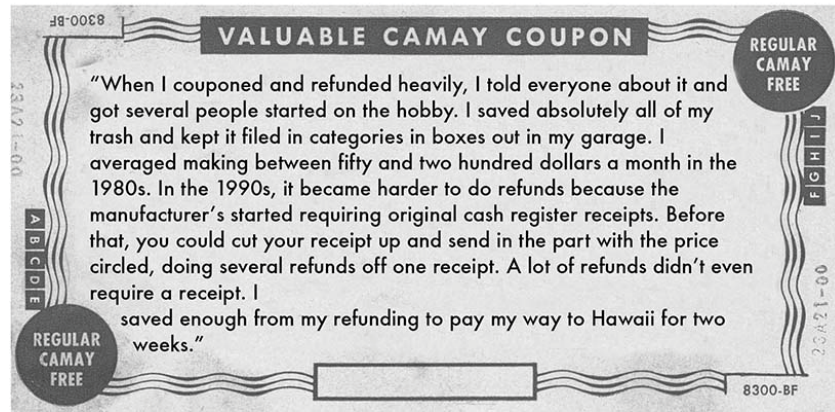




Compulsive? I lived and breathed refunding, and my children benefited with their wide variety of toys, balls, and T-shirts I obtained through my hobby. It was all a big game, and one that I played well. And I was not alone. While there was no estimate available on the number of people who were involved in refunding, Carol Backs, publisher of *Money Maker* magazine in the late 1980s and chairman of a trade association of refund magazine publishers, claimed that refund magazines were selling eight hundred thousand to one million subscriptions.

Not once during this time did I believe I was doing something morally suspect or illegal by having my mother save labels, digging in recycling centers, or ordering extra coffee-makers with lids from coffee that someone else drank. But if I'd been among those receiving "the letter" from the Postmaster General that I'd heard about in the refund bulletins and magazines, perhaps I would have thought differently. I'd seen vague references to it in my refund magazines and bulletins but didn't think it applied to me. I hadn't traded with any of the women who were indicted for fraud or I would have gotten one, too.